

GET BEHIND THE NEW YORK DECLARATION ON PALESTINE!

The New York Declaration issued at the conclusion of the international conference on Palestine in late July looks serious. The European Unions and most of the major European powers plus many other countries are declaring that the issue cannot be kicked down the road any longer.

They are talking about a UN mandated intervention to assist the Palestinian Authority, the widely recognized government of Palestine, in taking back Gaza and the West Bank from the Israeli occupiers, in implementing a democratic reform process and holding elections, and in undertaking economic reconstruction. The plan would be presented at the UN in September.

There are two big concerns here. Will the US use its veto in the Security Council? And if they do what will the European powers do? Will they seriously challenge the veto power that allows the three undesirables, China, Russia and the USA to veto two-third majority resolutions of the General Assembly? Could they possibly organize a coalition of the willing with enough military, diplomatic and economic punch to compel Israel to stand aside and cooperate in the process? Or would they just say "well we tried our best but we met an impermeable brick wall"?

The other concern is the role of the Arab regimes. They are all autocracies that do not want to see Palestine succeeding as a democracy. The last thing they want is that country providing a "bad example" for the rest of the Arab world. Their attitude would be a lot like that of Putin when he witnessed a burgeoning democracy in Ukraine, a country where a large minority spoke Russian as a first language and everyone else spoke it as a second one, and where many people had relatives over the border. So involvement of these regimes has to greatly constrained.

High on the priorities of this process should be obtaining the release of Marwan Barghouti, "Palestine's Mandela", from Israeli prison where he resides on trumped up charges. He is the biggest individual force for democracy and Palestinian unity.

According to the Declaration, following a ceasefire, a transitional administrative committee would be established immediately to operate in Gaza under the umbrella of the Palestinian National Authority. Barghouti should play a role in this. Indeed, his role should be announced as part of the pressure to release him.

The committee would be supported by the deployment of a temporary international stabilization mission, at the invitation of the Palestinian Authority. This force will provide protection for the

Palestinian civilian population, support the transfer of internal security responsibilities to the Palestinian Authority and provide security guarantees, including monitoring of the ceasefire and a future peace agreement. A number of countries have already promised troops. The PA has undertaken to hold elections within a year throughout Palestine including East Jerusalem under international auspices. There will also be international support for reform programs focused on good governance, transparency and financial sustainability. There are also commitments to extensive reconstruction aid.

The whole business is going to require a lot of cooperation from Israel, and this will not happen unless that country is placed under considerable pressure. This is doable, if there is the will, given that it is a small country very reliant on the west.

According to the Declaration, Israel will have to accept that there is going to be a Palestinian state based on the 1967 borders, including East Jerusalem. An immediate priority will be bringing their "settlers" under control. They don't mention it, but there will also need to be a 50-60 kilometer land bridge between Gaza and the West Bank much like the link between West Germany and West Berlin back in the day.

This whole initiative would benefit greatly from manifestations of popular support. So, it will be interesting to see how the "Free Palestine" crowd react to it. Much of the "revolutionary left" won't like it because according to them the Palestinians can only be delivered from the Israelis by some distant proletarian revolution. ■

Ecosocialism and Degrowth are Great Ways to Become Irrelevant *Platypus Review 167*



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ECOSOCIALISM AND DEGROWTH ARE PURE FOLLY

Ecosocialism has become all the rage among quite a few "left" sects. They believe that we need to degrow the economy to some much lower steady state if we are to reduce greenhouse emissions and save the biosphere, and that this cannot be achieved under capitalism with its drive to accumulate.

This "success" is remarkable given that the whole idea is so obviously and totally at odds with reality. Let's be clear. Capitalism is not going to be overthrown and replaced in any relevant timeframe. And the only alternative - communism - will not happen without considerable growth. So if we really need degrowth to save the planet, then we are stuffed and there is nothing to be done.

Decoupling with technofix is the way to go

The more fruitful option is to concentrate one's efforts on prodding the present system to do a far better job of decoupling our increasing economic activity from undesirable environmental impacts. In part this means working for a much quicker pace of technofix. The biggest present failing here is the far too low government funding of relevant research and development, and of the demonstration and initial deployment of new "clean" technologies. The shackles imposed on nuclear power are another problem. As for the conversion of rainforests and other natural areas to other land uses, this is not something that capitalism actually requires, so, there is scope for an evidence and results based environment movement to make a big difference.

Despite poor funding the amount of innovation in the last decade has been remarkable. So, better resourcing is bound to bring faster and better results. Renewable energy has made considerable progress. There have been some major breakthroughs in enhanced geothermal energy technology. Plant-based meat alternatives plus cultured meat promise to reduce land and water use with all its problems. Precision farming and genetic engineering can reduce emissions from crop growing. Progress is being made in developing "green" cement, steel and aluminum. And now that we started looking, we have discovered that hydrogen in its elemental state does indeed exist in vast quantities under our feet.

Degrowthers are not impressed. They have three objections. (1) Technofixes just create new and probably bigger problems. (2) Even if you reduce environmental impact to a satisfactory level at present output, growth will eventually increase that impact back up to a damaging level. (3) Decoupling is too slow given the urgency

continued overleaf

THINKING ABOUT FREEDOM AND EQUALITY

Classical liberals consider themselves the best defenders of freedom and equality. They frown upon any interference with our person or property, and support equal opportunity in life's many contests.

In their mind the right to private property and any resulting revenue stream is of course the most sacred "liberty". They also believe that success in the scramble for wealth and position should depend on luck and merit, unrestricted by irrelevant considerations such as race, sex, shoe size or whatever.

Taxation is considered tantamount to theft while expropriating the assets of capitalists - the means of production - is seen as an attack on the very foundations of liberty. However, at the risk of spoiling the party, I can imagine a situation where this expropriation would not really deprive them of anything and they would have no grounds for complaint.

Imagine workers (wage and salary earners) decide they are no longer prepared to work for the capitalists. So in order to keep the economy running they have no alternative except to take over the means of production and operate them themselves.

However, the capitalists are not really being deprived of anything. The means of production are not a direct source of enjoyment and they cannot provide any revenue if workers refuse to work for them.

At the same time the capitalists will have to "voluntarily" abandon their extravagant lifestyle because they will no longer have the funds to sustain it. Mansions, private jets and yachts have very high running costs.

So that's capitalist freedom dealt with. What about "equality"? The classical liberals say they are big fans of equal opportunity but not of equal outcomes.

More equal outcomes require taxing the rich to give to the poor. This is considered not only theft but a disincentive to work that can only lead to a shrinking economic pie.

Equal opportunity, however, gets an approving nod. We are all better off if the talented and hardworking are given a chance to do their best and be rewarded accordingly. Laws or customs should not introduce irrelevant considerations such as race, sex or religion. Although if you mention the advantage of having wealthy parents the conversation can turn awkward.

A revolutionary regime working towards a classless society would of course be very much into evening out outcomes. Just removing the prospect of being a wealthy capitalist would be a big start of course. The really high salaries would also be eliminated. Although, it will be necessary to bribe some of the people you temporarily cannot do without from the old society.

Pay differentials would be progressively reduced. In a society that has achieved a certain level of "affluence", there is no insurmountable reason why it could not fairly readily get to a stage where no one's living standards are much

higher than the average. This would apply even to the top leadership, removing any material basis for turning themselves into a new bourgeoisie.

Success will depend on how readily we transform our motivations for working. You can only get rid of the bossy division of labor and big wage differences if we become able and willing to work well in their absence.

You can expect people's motivations for work to change if they see that the economy is focused on meeting everyone's common needs, that their work environment is becoming less and less toxic, that they are able to develop their abilities and do interesting stuff, that they are not going to end up on the work scrap heap, and that work and its duration is not allowed to interfere too much with other aspects of their lives.

Achieving all this will require a revolutionary movement with the critical mass and smarts to deal with fear of the unfamiliar and the fact that quite a few people have something invested in existing unequal arrangements. ■

Ecosocialism cont'd

of achieving zero emissions and protecting the biosphere.

Does technofix just create new problems?

Bagging nuclear power and genetic engineering are always top of the list when talking about the dire effects of technofix. It is appalling how this stuff is quite mainstream, particularly in Europe.

There is nothing about the new technologies that would overall make them more dangerously extractive compared with those that have been with us for some time. Besides, we should expect cleaner methods and practices.

Reducing land use seems quite manageable. Land saving technologies in agriculture and human settlement are progressing quite nicely. Renewables are more land intensive than fossil fuel power while nuclear and geothermal take up little land. Hydrogen distribution presumably would have a similar impact as fossil fuel distribution.

In the case of water use, we would expect to see considerable reductions as a result of the new technologies in agriculture, industry and domestic consumption.

With both land and water use, you then just have to ensure that the bulk of resources freed up go back to nature rather than some new human use.

Is decoupling temporary?

If products require materials in their production you will eventually hit limits. You might increase the yields of tree plantations and design wood products so that they do not need as much of that material. However, at some point these gains will be exhausted and you will have to increase the area devoted to trees. There is a similar story with the land required for increasing amounts of wind and solar energy.

Substitutions are no help in the long term. You can use aluminum or plastic instead of wood. But increasing their use is bound to require more extraction, land and water, either directly or indirectly. There is a similar problem with pollution if it increases at all with growing output.

We also have to take account of the fact that the more stuff we have the more space it takes up leaving less for nature.

This is all quite correct. They are expressing the truism that you cannot infinitely increase production of stuff on a finite planet. But how relevant is this?

The biggest reductions in land and water will be in agriculture and this is a sector where we can expect growth to greatly slow down once everyone is well fed and the population stabilizes or even starts falling. There will be a similar story to some extent with human settlement. We will become better at building up in the air and down into the ground and better at recycling water. There could well be considerable reductions even if we find new uses for water and floor space and they grow at a modest rate.

Wind and solar are not limited to land but could increasingly be offshore while nuclear and geothermal use little land.

Material consumption in poorer countries will increase dramatically as they develop over the next half century or so. However, most of this will be construction material which is not a major cause of environmental damage. Besides, this surge will eventually slow down as this basic development task is completed.

Decoupling looks even less temporary when we take into account the fact that the science and technology of future centuries will give our descendants vastly greater ability to both harness and care for the natural environment. These would no doubt seem to us like magic if someone were to come back and tell us about them, much like someone now traveling back to 1900 with a dozen copies of *Wired* magazine.

Are we too late?

Degrowthers are right that we could reduce greenhouse gases and other environmental impacts more quickly if we were degrowing the economy. And it is also true that the general inadequacy of our efforts so far have built in considerable delays. However, we are still left with the fact that ecosocialist degrowth is just non-operational silliness.

The revolution needs growth

For Marxists, growth and the elimination of economic backwardness is the primary prerequisite for successful revolution. Reaching a high level of development creates the prospect of sharing material prosperity, humanizing work and having ample free time. We have a long history showing how we are not prepared to share the opposite - poverty and toil. These two blights have been the very basis of class society. So, we need to achieve a level of material conditions where the benefits of living in a convivial classless society considerably outweigh the benefits of being a "winner" under capitalism. ■